Jarvis siblings in conversation

Interviewer: Thank you very much for agreeing to participate. I really appreciate the time to have chat with you about your Judaism. This focus group is a qualitative dive into questions about who you are now, Jewishly, and the ways in which your upbringing might have shaped that. Rather than ask your parents I'm interested in you talking about yourselves.

I have only two questions and want to ask you each separately, but I want you to encourage you to listen to each other and contribute.

Question one is 'How you see yourselves Jewishly now". And question two, relates to your upbringing and any events, influences or people who you think might have contributed to the Jewish identity you have taken on, and how you see yourself now Jewishly. So, Jeremy, you want to start off?

Jeremy: Sure.

Interviewer: How would you describe yourself, in terms of your Judaism?

Jeremy: Sure. So, I guess I would say I'm Modern Orthodox. I think that that term has been maybe a bit misconstrued in our community and maybe in the diaspora more, but I think what it truly means is that there is a truth to the world and that truth is that God exists, that God gave the Jewish people the Torah and that God wants and determines our, that God desires us to act in a certain way, and behave in a certain way with certain values and moral and ethics. And I think that part of that is to be part of the modern world and to embrace the modern world but understand the limitations or at least – not the limitations but that there's a right way and a wrong way to go about things. And we were put on this planet to work it, we were put on this planet to make it a better place. So therefore, we have to incorporate ourselves within that world but we have to make sure that we do that in the right way.

So, I think that's what Modern Orthodox is and I think that's hopefully something that I try to act upon or within that hashkafa. So I think Judaism for me, I think at the core of what it is, is God. And without it, there would be no understanding of what a religion is. Everything that streams from Judaism comes from God or at least an inspiration from God. So, I think Judaism for me is centred around this idea and that idea is about so many wonderful and different perspectives but I guess the whole outlook or world view is that I was put on this world for a reason, for certain tafkid. I'm not sure why. Figuring that out, I guess, is part of my job and I guess I go from there.

That's Judaism for me and I think more than maybe my other siblings, I've had more of a **tumultuous relationship** with Judaism or with religion as a whole. I think that I always - I'm really happy and - I really believe that my parents, especially my mum, raised me or raised us with wonderful values. Inherently good values or values that I think are inherently involved with the Torah, chessed, of trying to be productive, of trying to be a good person, of working on yourself, on developing one's characteristics and one's middot. So I guess **my mum from the earliest of ages imprinted that within me** hopefully the right way to behave and to try and be a good person.

I think all is well and good and I think there is this spectrum of being able to be a good person without following the Taryag mitzvot. But I think then, **the big switch** I guess or maybe another massive influence I think was when I was at yeshiva, or at least maybe when I was independent.

So, I think that shift was when I turned 18, 19, when I went on a gap year, when I wasn't just in the cycle of either youth movement and school and work and whatever, just this constant cycle. That routine that doesn't make you think or doesn't really broaden your worldview on things but I think when I was independent when I was overseas and had to think a bit more and I guess maybe even the summer before I went away. Like I had to think, "What am I doing now?" Because there was no school, so this whole system that was keeping me afloat for so long had been taken away. And I think that thankfully, I found my way to yeshiva, and I think yeshiva was a massive, massive, massive boost or at least solidified what my mum had told me but I guess also a truthful way, or true to me –

Interviewer: Where did you go for yeshiva?

Jeremy: I started at […] for Shana Alef and then I moved to the […] and I did half a Shana Bet at […] Yeshiva. And I think thankfully, I - and also, I came back with a really good structure as well. I had Bnei [Akiva], I had a frum family and brothers who were frum - and a sister – sorry! [all laugh] I just had a really healthy structure which allowed me to continue growing in religion. But I think the actualisation or the - not the catalyst but the thing that switched it was that time in yeshiva, which was - it was a really fundamental part of my development.

Jo-Jo: Can I ask, what made you go to yeshiva? Because originally, you started on Limmud [a kibbutz program] and if you said yeshiva was **the click**, what made you - something had to make you go to yeshiva in the first place.

Jeremy: I think just naturally because you're out of this environment, maybe it was just hard for me, a readjustment, to be out of school and miss that routine, made me just question and challenge things on a daily level that I've never had before. I think when you're in Israel and you're challenging things, I guess it's a natural thing that you just end up - especially I guess because I was on Limmud. I don't know if you know, but I started on Limmud, and then went to […] and then to the […] yeshiva. And I think -

Jo-Jo: That's a huge switch.

Jeremy: I think when I was at - I was in a frum environment, I was on a Bnei Akiva program. so obviously, there was - I was challenging things and I think the natural development of action is to learn about it, and you do that at yeshiva.

Interviewer: Cool. When did you get back from Israel?

Jeremy: I got back July 2017.

Interviewer: Okay, so are you studying now, are you working?

Jeremy: I'm studying. I completed - I also did another course at - well, I didn't finish it - I was doing Commerce in […] University, did 18 months of that, then I changed to […]. Construction management at RMIT, but every summer, I've actually gone back

Commented [User1]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme focuses on metaphors and labels created by the siblings to define the "substance" of their identity.

Jeremy uses the term "**the big switch**" to describe his religious actualization.

Commented [User2]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme uses sibling dialogue to distinguish between "identity optimization" and "fundamental crisis," and to map the move from conferred to agentic identity.

Jeremy describes the transition from a **conferred identity** (the "cycle" of school and youth movement) to an **agentic identity** triggered by his time in yeshiva. He identifies this as "**the big switch**" where he moved from a routine that "doesn't make you think" to a "truthful way" that was "true to me".

Commented [User3]: 1. Real-Time Verification and Narrative Repair
This theme captures "interactional action units" where siblings act as "truth-checkers" to corroborate or challenge narratives.

Jo-Jo intervenes with a **repair sequence** while Jeremy is describing his religious journey. He notes that Jeremy originally started on a secular kibbutz program (*Limmud*) and asks, "If you said yeshiva was **the click**, what made you—something had to make you go to yeshiva in the first place?". This forces Jeremy to clarify the transition from a "routine" to an "independent" search.

Cross-reference: Continued below (~~)

to Israel, mainly to yeshiva. Last time, I went on Ulpan. But beyond that, I spent more time in yeshiva throughout those - in the summers in between. I'm 23.

Interviewer: Right. 'Tumultuous' was a word you used earlier. You said that you going away was a surprise because things were tumultuous?

Jeremy: Yeah. I think I talk about a lot... Coming out of a routine I guess is just - I guess school is just - I see it a lot when I'm in chinuch that I had been involved in the previous few years, a lot of people just breeze through school, kids just go with the flow of what it's like to go through school and they don't really think so heavily, they don't really challenge things and then I guess when I was away, I was maybe a bit homesick and just thinking deeply about other things like why am I here, what's the purpose, what's - and I guess it is a tumultuous experience for those who go on that journey.

Interviewer: I guess also in Australia, understanding of vocabulary is assumed. There, you say, "I'm [Modern Orthodox congregation]," and someone says, "What does that mean?" so actually, you have to think about what that might mean. Part of explaining to others is explaining to self. Sounds interesting. Jo-Jo?

Jo-Jo: Okay, so I was probably a bit different to Jeremy in terms of I didn't do as much of a - I've been relatively stagnant religiously for most of my life. I think throughout school, I didn't really - similar to what Jeremy was saying, I didn't really question things, I just did it. I would keep shabbat and would keep kosher and would just do things. A lot of my friends did as well which did make it easy, my year level, it was a relatively religious one, so most of my friends were shomer shabbat, so it wasn't difficult and I didn't have social issues like that for example.

But then, I think one of the big things for me definitely in terms of my Jewish identity was definitely on Shnat. My gap year I think was a real transformative and influential period. I was on Limmud for the year. For a lot of the - if I had my time again, I would've probably moved to MTA halfway through and for a lot of the year, I was grappling whether to move or not.

Again, I can't change now so it doesn't matter but I remember at the time I was thinking to myself, I was speaking to a lot of the guys at Eretz. Because a lot of my friendship group were Eretz guys and they went to yeshiva, but we had a relatively religiously liberal group. So we had quite a few that weren't just there to muck around, they were there to learn and grow and to try and get as much as they could out of the program which obviously helped me. I think definitely being in Israel and just experiencing Israel, even - it'll sound weird but even for free weekends, we'd go to Modi'in and other random places, and you'd see whole communities that were shomer shabbat and fully Modern Orthodox.

I don't know what it was but it just this new sort of paradigm that [pause] I don't know how it influenced me but it just opened my eyes up to a new level of Orthodoxy, similar to what Jeremy was saying that here, Modern Orthodoxy is a big spectrum. And there, you have people from yishuvim and different towns, they would call themselves Modern Orthodox but here, they'd probably be seen as hareidi really, really frum. And I think seeing whole communities like that and being exposed to whole groups like that really opened my eyes. And for me being in Israel definitely was a very influential part of what it was to be Jewish. Before my gap year, I didn't really think so much about things.

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Cross-reference: Continued from above (~~)

I just did it because – whether it was expected from the community – I didn't take a step back and think like, 'Why am I doing this?' One thing I regret a bit, I didn't really learn - I never read out a chevruta or whatever during school.

I remember once I did with a Hesder boy once but otherwise, I didn't really learn much. Coming back, I've tried to learn a bit more and whatever and I think in terms of me, I'm probably not as religious as Jeremy, Jeremy is probably more religious than me but I definitely do see Judaism as very - an internal part of my life, it's something that's really important and it's something that has been important throughout my life and obviously, I have times when I struggle and find things difficult.

But ultimately, I do believe that God has a very big part to play and I think that it's quite hard to maintain a strong Jewish identity without somewhat of a belief in God or at least to have some discussion on it. For people to say there's no such thing, for me at least and from what I've learnt, it just means that it won't perpetuate. For me, that's an important thing to at discuss and grapple with.

But in terms of level of religion, I'm not super different to what I was before Shnat. I think before Shnat, I was definitely a bit stricter in terms of trying to wear tzitzit, daven three times a day and those sorts of things that I wasn't as stringent on, and obviously since then. When I first came back from Shnat, you know, you're on a big of a high. And it definitely was easier because I was in Bnei and I was around my friends and I had quite an easy structure to do it in. But then once Bnei ended, it was a bit difficult but again, because my group of friends are mostly shomer shabbat, it wasn't as difficult.

You get quite a few people that once they leave Bnei, it's quite easy for them to **tip over and lose a lot** of their Yiddishkeit. But I think for me and a lot of my friend group, we're maybe not as religious as we were but we at least we've still got a level that we do keep and which makes us - we all keep Shabbat. And I think ultimately, a lot of who and how I am now comes down to Shnat. For me at least. In terms of growing up, I think I was actually **speaking to my mum about it** today, she said one of the things - actually, we were just speaking because I was speaking about work and we were speaking about Jewish education and she that she wanted to send us to [Modern Orthodox school] because she wanted to instil strong Jewish values in us and I think we definitely got that growing up.

It was a very big part of how we were brought up and the way that - always making sure to look out for people if they needed a meal and this and that and that was a really big thing, always to make sure that if there was someone that was not invited to a party or something, to try and make extra effort to make sure that they were invited to something and all that sort of stuff. So, I think that sort of stuff, chessed, hachnasat orchim, was a very big part growing up, it's something that Mum and Dad tried to instil in us a lot.

In terms of Israel stuff, we didn't have a lot of that growing up actually. I feel like - I know it's a bit of a separate subject, but a lot of my Zionism is very much from Bnei and then because by being in Israel, it obviously helped with my Zionism and then obviously influenced my Judaism, and that was a real - I think for me, Shnat was a really big turning point and then coming back, it has been hard because when you're there in Israel, you're surrounded by it, you don't have to think twice about wearing tefillin, davening. I remember even on the flight back, I was in Bangkok,

and I was at the airport and I was davening in tefillin and people were looking at me. And for the last year, no one would bat an eyelid at that, because in Israel, it's the norm. That's me. A lot of my Jewish identity comes from being in Israel

Also Bnei helped a lot with that. I really enjoyed being a madrich so that helped also maintain that Jewish identity.

And I think as well, **having my siblings** has been a really - especially post-Bnei has been a really big influence on me and **has really helped me** because that's made it a lot easier, having - if I see that my siblings are davening, then it'll prompt me too and especially during COVID when you can't get to a minyan, that's helped. So, definitely, **they're very good influences on me**.

And Jeremy actually got me in touch with Rav […] to learn with him and that's been really good and I've been learning with him for a few years now and it's really great. I think also, a lot of it comes down to learning. I think Jewish learning is a really important part, even again if you're not particularly religious, it's important to know things. I think people think that they're all rabbis and rebbetzins after they hear one drasha, but a lot comes down to learning and actually understanding and I think that's a big part of it as well.

Interviewer: Thank you. How old are you? What occupies your days now? Are you working, studying?

Jo-Jo: I'm 25, I work for the ZFA and Masa, I'm one of the MASA representatives. I'm the Marketing Assistant to the Israel Programs Department. It has been really tough during COVID. Trying to market travelling - it's been an interesting year. What else? I've just been stuck at home a lot trying to keep fit.

Interviewer: Thank you Jo-Jo. Benny?

Benny: Sure. I guess similar to Jeremy, I believe in Torat Moshe. I believe that the Torah was given by God and I believe that as a Modern Orthodox Jew that halacha reigns supreme and that I should try and live in this modern world and contribute to the modern world but halacha always reigns supreme. That's where I'm at in a very short sense, I can go into more detail but I think I'll do that as I go through my story if that helps and I'll talk a bit about - and I think that'll impact where I am today.

It may be a bit unidentifiable so you may have to cut out a few things but I think it's important to start that **I think our home growing up wasn't so Jewish in a sense of learning because our parents - my dad converted and my mum grew up in a Traditional house and didn't go to a Jewish school** so when my dad converted and they went to marry Orthodox, **they both didn't really know very much** and had to learn themselves and I think a lot about Jewish learning was from school and Bnei and that sort of thing because we didn't really have that at home just because our parents didn't - and unfortunately really still don't know very much.

They try and want to learn and I remember growing up, they were always so envious of us. Always saying, "**You are so lucky you have Hebrew**!" And when you're year seven, you're like [grimaces] "I hate Hebrew", that's such a contrast. Yeah. I look back now and I wish I could absorb all those lessons again. But at school, at that time, we hated it. Don't we all want to go back in time through life?

Commented [User5]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
The transcript functions as a **mesosystemic laboratory**, mapping how macro-systemic factors are filtered through relational dynamics.

Relational (Siblings): Benny credits his high level of observance to the **relational support** of his brothers and sister: "the fact that they were going through Bnei at that time... all of us have had each other". He explicitly states that his siblings are "very good influences on me".

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Commented [User6]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
The transcript functions as a **mesosystemic laboratory**, mapping how macro-systemic factors are filtered through relational dynamics.

Macro (School/Community) & Relational (Family): Benny explains that because their father converted and their mother did not have a Jewish education, the **Macro-system** (the Modern Orthodox school and Bnei Akiva) became the primary source of their Jewish literacy. Their parents were "envious," telling the children, "You are so lucky you have Hebrew!".

Cross-reference: Continues below (!!)

[pause] A big turning point for me was in year eleven. I remember when my school - they announced that if we wanted to be in school leadership, that there were certain requirements and one of those was you had to keep fully kosher. So our family grew up eating non-kosher out. Our house was kosher but we ate out vegetarian. So, I remember that being one of the rules and I was like, “All right, I think I’m going to try and keep fully kosher,” – at the time, to the horror of my siblings [laughs, they all laugh] – I think that was the first time when I really was trying to take on more. That was big.

I remember growing up, there wasn’t - as I think Jo-Jo said, there wasn’t much of a connection to Israel in our house. My parents were both very Australian and I think that was something that I didn’t really understand a lot. I didn’t go to Bnei much as a chanich, I was heavily involved as a madrich but not really as a chanich. And I think my Israel learning and relationship didn’t really develop until a few state Zionist camps and when I started taking a bit more interest towards that later secondary school, but I never really understood this connection very much growing up.

I think as a family, we didn’t discuss Israel really at all, it was all just from [Modern Orthodox school]. That was my interaction with Israel. It’s funny, one of my friends has a memory of us being on one of those year nine Zionist camps – one of those emotional and moving camps – and he said that he remembered me saying “Be’eztar Hashem I’ll go on Tafnit!” But really, at the time, I didn’t understand why anyone would want to go to Israel. Why would anyone want to you spend a year there? It just didn’t really make sense to me which I don’t know, maybe it’s just the family that we had and Israel was never really a huge part of it I guess.

So, in year eleven, I was trying to become more frum, keeping shabbat, then in year twelve, I had a chevruta and started being more interested. Something also that I enjoyed was layning, I really love layning. And I said, “These are my passions. I love layning, I love shul” – which is strange, because not everyone likes those things because prayer really hard, but I really enjoy it – And I thought, “All right, I’ll focus on this, I’ll find the enjoyment and satisfaction out of that and then hopefully that can spread to other aspects of my Jewish life.”

When I went to the […]. It probably wasn’t the right place for me. I think Tafnit or Limmud would have been a better program in terms of what I would - my personality, I would’ve loved the more rounded program, spending six weeks on kibbutz, Machon, army, maaravah.

I actually think that would’ve been better for me but I went to […] because of the people who were there with me. My friends I think were more serious than I was. For me, it was like, “All right, let’s give this serious Judaism a shot and see what Torah is about.” [pause] I think for Jeremy, it was - Jeremy is a lot more about learning. But for me, it was more about davening as a way to experience connection. Shnat wasn’t as transformative for me, say, as the others.

It was - I think that what Jo-Jo mentioned about it was more than the learning which was - obviously, I learnt a lot and I think something that Jo-Jo was saying was that I think the more you learn, the more you realise you don’t know what the - the more you know, the more you realise you don’t know.

Jo-Jo: The killer learning paradox.

Commented [User7]: 1. Real-Time Verification and Narrative Repair
This theme captures "interactional action units" where siblings act as "truth-checkers" to corroborate or challenge narratives.

Benny recalls a moment in Year 11 when he decided to keep "fully kosher," noting it was "to the horror of my siblings [laughs, they all laugh]". The shared laughter and recognition of this event serve as **intersubjective grounding** for the family’s religious evolution.

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Macro (School/Community) & Relational (Family): Benny explains that because their father converted and their mother did not have a Jewish education, the **Macro-system** (the Modern Orthodox school and Bnei Akiva) became the primary source of their Jewish literacy. Their parents were "envious," telling the children, "You are so lucky you have Hebrew!".

Cross-reference: Continues from above (!!)

Benny: That was what […] Yeshiva taught me a lot. Obviously, I learnt a lot of stuff as well but I think that for me, Israel was about seeing Modern Orthodoxy and Judaism at its pinnacle and that was really inspiring for me, seeing people living in Israel, observing all the mitzvot that they could and living while also having jobs that we have here, lawyers and doctors and teachers and everything, so that was impactful I think more so than the actual yeshiva experience in terms of learning about Judaism.

Something on those lines which has impacted my Judaism for a while or had - and I'll tell you when I got over that a little bit - was the notion of aliya. I always grew up very Australian as I said and I never really had wanted to make aliya and I felt this - when you go to Bnei and when you go [Modern Orthodox school], it's always about aliya. And it never really made sense to me, I didn't really understand why because life here in amazing, baruch Hashem.

I remember it used to get me down when I came back from Shnat and was in Bnei, I felt conflicted and very like, "How can I be madrich if I don't know if I'm going to make aliya?" And it feels like for me, Judaism – and with anything you sign up for – if you sign up you do it properly! You do everything or you don't do any. And if aliya is a mitzva, then what are we doing here? How are we here? And it bothered me for a really long time and I get - I don't want to say depressed. It bothered me and I felt like a contradiction and particularly for my first two years of Bnei, I had issues. And then when I became Merakez, I was like, "Benny, you can't let this get you down. You've got to focus and just be on the ball and everything." For it it's not just with Judaism, I think it's my personality. I remember people saying in maths that people had to be quiet because maths is important but those same people would talk in Hebrew. And I always felt that was really wrong, why would you - just people who are contradictory like that.

So, it always bothered me that I was not perfect and it took a while until - I think it was probably my Merakez where I really realised that no one's perfect. As a human, we're imperfect by nature, we all make mistakes, we all sin and it took me to realise that, hopefully we should all strive to perfection but know that we'll never achieve that but each year and each day, try and get better and better and try and improve wherever we can. So, I'm not - say, I'm not going to make aliya? Okay, it's not the ideal and to know that the ideal is as I said to follow all the mitzvot, and I hope this is with everyone.

I don't - in a sense, I care but if someone says, "This doesn't exist, it's not a mitzva to keep shabbat," I think that that's heretical. But if someone says, "I know that keeping shabbat is the right thing to do. I'm not there yet but I hope to get there," I think that's a different mindset. And that's what I think with all the halachot and mitzvot. Aliya I grew to be less upset about that in my life.

So, I think I'm in a place where I'm understanding and more content that I'm not perfect, no one's perfect but I'm trying to grow and improve every day, year, et cetera and I think post-Bnei as Jo-Jo said, it is easy to drop off a little bit or you lose that framework and that framework is so important and I remember actually then, I - so, for me as I said, davening was really important to me.

In fact, if I didn't get up to minyan I'd be in a really - I'd just be upset because I miss minyan and then I'm upset and my day's not gone well and sometimes I wouldn't even put on tefillin and nobody likes hearing some friends who they're not really

Commented [User9]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme focuses on metaphors and labels created by the siblings to define the "substance" of their identity.

Benny/Jo-Jo refer to the "**killer learning paradox**"—the idea that "the more you know, the more you realise you don't know".

Commented [User10]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme uses sibling dialogue to distinguish between "identity optimization" and "fundamental crisis," and to map the move from conferred to agentic identity.

Benny describes a "Searching Moratorium paradox" regarding *Aliyah*. He felt "bothered" and "contradictory" because he didn't want to move to Israel, feeling that "if you sign up you do it properly!". His resolution—realizing that "as a human, we're imperfect by nature" and deciding to "do what works for me"—is a clear example of **identity optimization** rather than a crisis of faith.

Cross-reference: Continued below (%%)

religious but they put on tefillin every day, and I never really understood people that had those - people have their own things they connect to, and that's awesome.

But I guess I remember Rav Taragin was here from Israel for Shavuot a few years ago and he said something - it wasn't said directly to me but I remember he said something like, "No matter how low you feel, you can always come back, you can always get better, you can always improve," and that really set the motion for me again to try and say, "All right, this is where I am. Who cares that I didn't make minyan today? I'm going to try and make minyan tomorrow. It doesn't mean I'm a bad person, it doesn't mean I'm a bad Jew. I am going to try." And from now, I think I really - thank God I've set the wheels in motion to lift up again, and I think I'm actually honestly probably frummer now than I was in Bnei, more connected and more interested which is pretty rare.

Jeremy always says, "Benny, it's like a miracle," and I think a credit to my siblings for that, because the fact that they were going through Bnei at that time. I think all of us have had each other and it's been really, really helpful.

So, now I really try and learn every single day and daven three times a day and keep fully kosher and try and do things that I think are really important and as I said, I think that understanding that, "Okay, so aliya I still don't think honestly that I'm ready to make that step now," but other times, I was thinking about it earlier in the year and whatever but it was like, "Okay. In a sense, it's not the ideal. The ideal is to make aliya and we should all know that and it's okay to acknowledge that." I'm not at that stage yet. I'm going to try and do what works for me and what I - I can connect to it and I think that's really important that everyone finds something that they can connect to.

There's a bit and there's - in terms of learning, there's absolutely everyone, every single Jew has some sort of Jewish learning that they can connect to so if it's not about learning Gemara, then there's Chumash – I love Tanach. It's about finding your niche and the books you connect to. That's where I am at this moment.

To answer a bit about where I am right now is I'm 27, I work at a company called Rimon Advisory, so it's actually a Jewish firm which is really nice. I just started there about seven weeks ago. It's run al-pi halacha which is incredible and very lucky I think in Australia. We basically help small businesses and entrepreneurs get grants from the government in R&D and in exporting, so I've only been there a very short time but it's really cool to feel like - even before when I had my previous job at an economics advisory firm - just to wear a kippa in the city. For me, that's Modern Orthodoxy: getting up, going to shul, contributing to greater society. That was - I felt really excited about that and now it's the same, it's just more in a very Jewish context and all the employees are Jewish but that's where I'm at, at the moment.

Interviewer: Cool. Liba?

Liba: Hi. It's interesting now to reflect and think about all of these things and also after hearing the boys.

I think when I think of the influences on me in terms of religion, as Benny said, very much, values from our parents but that knowledge side and that understanding wasn't there, as Benny explained by virtue of the fact that they weren't exposed to that as children and as young people and even as adults.

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Cross-reference: Continued from above (%%)

Commented [User12]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
The transcript functions as a **mesosystemic laboratory**, mapping how macro-systemic factors are filtered through relational dynamics.

Relational (Siblings): Benny credits his high level of observance to the **relational support** of his brothers and sister: "the fact that they were going through Bnei at that time... all of us have had each other". He explicitly states that his siblings are "very good influences on me".

Cross-reference: Point continued above (**)

They've grown with us and I think really our family has grown as we the children have grown and developed and figured out what's important to us and how we want to live our lives.

I think Bnei was a really, really important influence on me as a place where - I always loved Bnei, I was always involved in Bnei, I'm still involved in Bnei, I'm going to be so sad when I have to leave Bnei one day - where especially as a senior chanicha and just having a lot of madrichot that were really instrumental in helping me understand who I was and who I wanted to be and really challenged me and really showed me that being religious is cool and fun and important and so fulfilling in that way, which I don't think you necessarily get at school in that same way.

But in saying that, I loved [Modern Orthodox school] and I really gained a lot from [Modern Orthodox school], I think certainly religiously but I really think Bnei just gave me a really important - it made me see how my life could be, it gave me really tangible role models of people that helped me and guided me and were really - and are still people who I really rely on and I know care about me and I care about them and I have a really strong relationship with and I think that has been a really important influence on me and my life.

I think as well, my year level has been really influential, particularly the girls who I've been with, it's a really, really strong group of girls baruch Hashem. Really. Our year level I think we all really were all quite similar in the way that we think, not in a way that's a group mentality but in a way that we really complement each other well and really strengthen each other and really push each other in a really positive way and in a really healthy and safe way. And I think particularly Jewishly, all of us I think are quite similar and quite religious and that influence on each other was always really positive and always pushing each other and helping each other.

To be honest, I'm not just talking in terms of my religious identity or Zionist identity but just really the person I am, I think my year level as well, particularly the girls really helped me be the person that I am. I think something interesting is I think I'm more religious now than when I was in school or on Shnat. I did Limmud at my gap year which I really, really loved and was a really important year for me. I was really lucky that the year group that I was with - again, I'm very blessed that I've had many amazing cohorts - the cohort of kids from Australia and South Africa were incredible, just really, really amazing people that really wanted to learn and grow and just explore. Most of them actually came from not so frum - I mean Traditional backgrounds, Scopus, Moriah or King David in South Africa.

So, I was more like the frum ones meaning everyone was very similar in where they wanted to be, but in terms of knowledge, it was a little bit different, not that I have very much knowledge but [Modern Orthodox school] was different to King David and Moriah in that way but still, I think that the yearning all of those people had to really grow and learn as much as they can, were so open minded to so many different people and so many different things was really, really important to me as well and a lot of those people, I'm still really, really close to. One of my best friends is from Shnat but I didn't know her at all and now, we're really, really, really close.

So, that is what I think really helped guide me. As the others said, when you're in school and [Modern Orthodox school] and Bnei, you daven at [Modern Orthodox synagogue] Bnei shul - it's very - that routine and then once you live in Israel on a

program - I was - no one else from Australian was with me on Limmud, it was very out of my comfort zone in that way, there wasn't really so many people who I knew but in that way, I think I really, really gained so much from those people and being in that environment out of my usual comfort zone and everything that I'm used to and the people that I'm used to.

I really think I am more religious now than I was in school and maybe - not by necessarily that much but in school and on Shnat, and I think it's because again, when - now that I'm out of that routine, I really can think about how I want to live my life and what is important to me because I don't just do it because the teachers tell me to do it or because my parents want me to do it or for whatever reason. These things really are important to me, Torah is really important to me, keeping mitzvot and davening are important to me and all of these things are really, really important to me and a really big part of my life and now, if that's going to happen, **it has to be on me** to be able to do that. It's not going to be on someone telling me to do that.

So, I think that has really made me stronger in that way and really tried to push myself in the way that I can to try and learn more or do more in whatever way that is and as the others said, having religious siblings is obviously also really helpful. We all complement each other and help each other and it's not a burden or difficult because we're all doing it together, so I think that's certainly important as well.

Interviewer: Can I jump in for a second? You said you're all doing it together. Is that COVID because you're together more, or do you think that that was something that was pre-COVID also?

Liba: I think certainly also pre-COVID. In saying that, of course we are on different religious levels and we are on - we do have debates about certain things and we do think differently on things, but I think overall, we would all classify ourselves as Modern Orthodox and really live that hashkafa and want to live that hashkafa in the future, and I think in that way, we do support each other, because it could be hard if one of us wasn't so interested, and then that shifts the dynamic a bit, whereas all of us, I think are interested in learning and keen to learn and keen to daven and keen to speak about those things.

So, I think that was certainly also helpful but I think something else which I guess Benny touched on. I think when I went to Israel, I really saw what Modern Orthodoxy really could be, which I think here in Australia, in maybe diaspora communities, I guess particularly in the smaller communities in Australia, it's, I think, **very cookie cutter**, "This is what being religious is," or, "This is what Orthodoxy is," or, "This is what religious Zionism is," and I think that when I went to Israel, I really saw the diversity of Orthodoxy and how broad that is and how beautiful it is and how diverse it is in a way that celebrates each other and I think that also really opened up my eyes of the person I wanted to be in that I think Melbourne is a small community and is lacking in ways and I saw in Israel, such a way where it is so fulfilling and so rich.

Again, not to put down the community, I think the community is amazing and it really, really is amazing and does so much but just in terms of people and institutions and organisations and everything, of course, we can't compare to Israel and I think that also influenced me and influenced the person that I want to be because it's not just the one cookie cutter version of what it means to be in a

Commented [User13]: 2. Disambiguating 'Searching' through Interactional Evidence
This theme uses sibling dialogue to distinguish between "identity optimization" and "fundamental crisis," and to map the move from conferred to agentic identity.

Liba provides interactional evidence of agentic choice, stating that she is "more religious now" specifically because she is "out of that routine" of school and parents. She argues that her commitment is now "on me" rather than a byproduct of teachers telling her what to do.

Commented [User14]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme focuses on metaphors and labels created by the siblings to define the "substance" of their identity.

Liba uses the metaphor "**cookie cutter**" to describe the narrow, uniform version of Orthodoxy she perceived in the Melbourne community, which she contrasts with the diversity she found in Israel.

[Modern Orthodox congregation]-frum. There's so many other things and ways and I think that also really spoke to me, that experience.

Interviewer: You said you're a madricha. What else, are you studying, are you working?

Liba: Yeah. I'm studying, I'm in my final year of my course which is scary. I'm doing biomedical science at uni at Monash which I really love. I really, really enjoy it. I'm working at Scopus in the Informal Team with Jared. So, they're the things that take up most of my time. I'm 21.

Interviewer: All right. Liba, do you feel like upbringing was different for you or that you sensed that there was something different for your brothers? Just wondering if in your upbringings, there was a sense of any differences for any reasons in diversity of the way you experienced being raised.

Liba: I think in terms of how I always were raised, certainly not. I always felt any opportunity that I wanted or any experience that the boys were afforded, I would definitely have that experience. Certainly, in the way we were brought up, I think it was really equal in that way, that we all - I always felt so fulfilled and obviously so loved and respected and everything in the same way. I guess at times, it can be difficult being a girl in Orthodox situations sometimes and that was difficult when I was growing up and I think particularly at school when I was in my older - when I was in upper secondary and also very much developing my own feminist identity and those things that were difficult but that's where I think - difficult in a way. I think that's really where my madrichot in Bnei really supported me and helped me or really helped me navigate that because it can be really difficult and can be isolating and it can be something that can be really difficult to reconcile. It's still something, it certainly is still a work in progress, it's something that can still be difficult and can irk me in certain situations and ways or in people's language or behaviour and those kinds of things but I really think now, I'm maybe more at peace with that if that makes sense, I really think that I've had really important influences that really helped guide me in that way particularly in Bnei and also when I was in Israel and on Shnat and really learning and growing with - I've always been around very strong and clever and competent girls and women within Orthodoxy which baruch Hashem which has really helped nurture that within me as well.

Jo-Jo: I really don't think that there was a difference in terms of Jewishly, I really don't think it was that the boys went to shul and Liba stays home - it was always if Liba wanted to do it, she could do it and she'd be encouraged to do it just as much as any of us.

Liba: Yeah, for sure. That's where I think my year level was also really instrumental in that, there was very much a culture with my best friends and my closest friends who were girls in my year who were as I said, really, really amazing, incredibly, very strong, capable women, that there was always a culture of being involved in Judaism and we know going to shul, I used to go to learn in the Beis [Beit Midrash], all of those things that maybe had traditionally been or maybe still are to an extent, male-dominated spaces. In that way, I always felt very empowered to be involved and I think part of that is certainly from our parents and being cognisant and making sure that those opportunities were available to me but also through Bnei and [Modern Orthodox school] and certainly with my year group, really being empowered and empowering each other to be engaged in these activities as well.

Commented [User15]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
The transcript functions as a **mesosystemic laboratory**, mapping how macro-systemic factors are filtered through relational dynamics.

Relational (Gendered filtering): Liba discusses how she developed a "**feminist identity**" within Orthodoxy. This individual Micro-level trajectory is mapped against the Relational-level discussion with Jo-Jo, who notes that gender did not play a role in household responsibilities ("we would all do the same responsibilities"), yet acknowledges the "difficult" paradigm for females in the broader religious Macro-system.

Cross-reference: Continues below (^^)

Jo-Jo: Also in terms of just everyday stuff, I don't think gender really played much of a role. We all had to make stuff, we'd all help out, it was like, "Boys, do one thing and Liba, do something other," I feel like it was very much we would all do the same responsibilities, it was never like we did one thing and they did something else.

Having Liba say this, **it has been really good for me to be able to hear what it's like on the girls' side** in terms of a lot of things, even davening and things that as a guy - and as a guy, I never will understand because I'm not a girl but to know what it's like to not be fully involved in the minyan, all those sorts of things and I think having ways is really good to give that firsthand experience and to realise that it is difficult and sometimes it is hard to understand and grapple with and I think ultimately as a guy, I'll never truly understand but it's really important.

Honestly, I think **a lot of guys will have discussions about these things, thinking that they know about it when they don't really because they don't really know what it feels like** and I think it's important for people to realise when they have these discussions to have that framework in mind. I'm not trying to say that they can't be in the discussion but to think they know exactly how the opposite side feels, they don't really and I think having Liba discuss these sorts of things, also from someone that believes in Torah and believes in God and also doesn't do it from a *davkanik* perspective, sometimes you may have people that want to try and abide by halacha. For me at least, really good to understand and to also understand the paradigm for females.

Interviewer: Thank you. In closing, I was wondering if you had an anecdote, a story, something which for you might reflect something from upbringing that you think is influential or that you might still carry with you today, a short story or a memory of something that might've occurred that might've been meaningful that lingers in you. Anyone?

Jo-Jo: I'll have a go. I think another thing that I realised when Benny was speaking, I really like - another transformative moment for me I actually remember vividly was when I was in year 12 and we broke the fast – usually after Yom Kippur, we break the fast at our uncle's house and my cousins, they don't keep kosher or whatever and I remember I had spent the whole day in shul and then it was the first meal after and I was eating this food that wasn't kosher and I was thinking to myself, 'What are you doing? You spent a whole day!' We ate out vegetarian growing up, we weren't fully kosher. And after that, for the next few months, I tried to and then pretty much since Shnat, I've been fully kosher. So I think for me, one of those things - and touching on from what Benny was saying - that was a point for me to try and always be working on something or to try and always be doing as much as I can and I think that's a really important thing. We're all very similar but what Benny was saying is I think I don't get too caught up if I miss a minyan or if I miss something, I don't beat myself up, I realise that I'm not perfect but ultimately, I think it's important to try and strive to do something

When you stand before God on Yom Kippur, I try to ask myself 'How am I different from last year?' even if it's saying 'Modeh Ani' every day or something like that but to try and think, 'What am I doing to try and make sure that I'm bettering myself as a person?' So, when I had that, I just remember that I was sitting there the first time after Yom Kippur, I literally just said for - because as well, I try and 'Al Chet' in English so I knew what I was saying and I knew that I had confessed to "We're sorry for eating the wrong food and drink," and I'm doing that literally an hour later

Commented [User16]: 1. Real-Time Verification and Narrative Repair
This theme captures "interactional action units" where siblings act as "truth-checkers" to corroborate or challenge narratives.

Jo-Jo and Liba engage in **meta-commentary** regarding gender dynamics within their upbringing. Jo-Jo acknowledges, "Hearing Liba say this, it has been really good for me to be able to hear what it's like on the girls' side," and admits that men often think they understand the female experience when they "don't really know what it feels like". This aligns with the manuscript's claim that sibling interaction disrupts individual memory bias.

Commented [User17]: 4. Mapping Multi-level Influences in a Single Transcript
The transcript functions as a **mesosystemic laboratory**, mapping how macro-systemic factors are filtered through relational dynamics.

Relational (Gendered filtering): Liba discusses how she developed a "**feminist identity**" within Orthodoxy. This individual Micro-level trajectory is mapped against the Relational-level discussion with Jo-Jo, who notes that gender did not play a role in household responsibilities ("we would all do the same responsibilities"), yet acknowledges the "difficult" paradigm for females in the broader religious Macro-system.

Cross-reference: Continued from above (^^)

and I'm thinking to myself, 'Surely you could've waited a bit longer.' At least tried a bit more.

Sometimes I fall short but that's - we all do - but I think it's ultimately trying to be on that path where you're trying to do what you can to make yourself a better Jew because when it comes down to it, I think one of the things I've definitely learnt from learning in chevruta and speaking a lot with people is that there's so much truth and so much importance to what Judaism brings. I think for a system to be able to withstand everything that it has, that it obviously must have some validity because if it didn't, then it would've died out and I think there are so many things about religion that people don't see as valuable but it is.

Just the basic thing of being a nice person is such an inherently religious trait but people - it's funny because pretty much the first part when I spoke, I mainly spoke about shabbat and kashrut but being a good person and making sure you pay people on time and all these sorts of things are religious traits which people don't really focus on. I think for me, it comes back down to there's a lot to learn, the more you learn, the more you realise all these things that are very inherently religious and are very much a part of your life and people don't tend to focus on it.

So, for me, it's realising as well that living a religious life and believing in God and leading that sort of lifestyle are such inherently religious things and there's so many things that people don't really recognise that they are religious but they are and that it's something that I definitely want to perpetuate because it has so much validity to who I am as a person and as to how we are as a society. I think ultimately, what religion stands for is very, very important and I think I'm trying to strive towards being those types of people and ultimately living their life is all very important.

Interviewer: Thank you, Jo-Jo.

Jeremy: It's not a particularly interesting topic but I remember being in […] Yeshiva and I had a very close friend who was from England and at dinner, we had a discussion and I guess coming from a Western, progressive society as Melbourne is - or was in 2015 then - we were having a discussion about homosexuality, and I remember having my point of view, and my point of view was I think the Torah is really cool and it makes a lot of sense and there's truth to it but they're wrong about what it says about homosexuality. And that was my contention and maybe my arrogance – and what my - he was chevrua, my friend, what he said at that time was, "Just because you don't understand it doesn't mean that it's wrong."

And it's just a really important point and I think it really shaped - as a whole, he actually had a really big influence on me - but really shaped my perspective that just because I don't understand something doesn't necessarily - or just because I think something's right doesn't mean it's right and I think that humility in grappling with new things or new concepts really changed things. I still think about that to this day. Maybe the topic of conversation is a bit interesting or a bit out there but I think a whole in life, I guess you don't have to trust things or trust people or trust systems, and when they're conflicting systems, then some seemingly are going to have to be incorrect viewpoints involved.

So, I think you're much safer to trust something like Judaism than you are to trust your own perspectives or how you see the world and through your eyes to that world, whether truth is within I guess. How do you see what seemingly could be divinely given? That was just a really, really big thing for me because I guess

basically from then, shifted that - the Torah says something, I think this – and try and bring myself to understand the Torah's perspective because even though I might not understand what that perspective is, as a whole, I think there's such a truthful perspective to that and from that conversation, it really rattled my train of thought and I guess I am to this day, because of that conversation.

Liba: I can go I guess. It's not necessarily a specific anecdote but something that I think was really important to me. I think it was Bnei Shul. As I said, I think Bnei was really a place for me where Judaism really became really accessible and really fulfilling and really complex in a way that maybe it wasn't presented to me at school.

At school, davening is very like, "You have to sit and shush and you have to sit and you have to whatever," or the same with the Jewish studies classes or those kind of things and I think my early secondary, I became a bit - not resentful, I was never anti-religion or whatever but I pushed back on that a bit and I started going to Bnei shul in year 10 for Kabbalat Shabbat. And I think it really transformed my whole view in a lot of - certainly of davening but also I think in Judaism, davening is an example for Judaism as a whole in that I fell in love with it straightaway.

It's such a beautiful service and such a highlight of my week, and just to bring in shabbat in such a beautiful way was so special and really showed me something that I thought was maybe boring and very methodical and something seeming this repetitive, monotonous task was actually something so beautiful and fulfilling and transported me emotionally and I'd never really interacted with Judaism in that way. I guess the crescendo of that is Rosh Hashana and Yom Kippur, which is really the highlight of my year, unfortunately not this year, which is devastating.

I remember when I was year eight madricha, I told my chanichot which was my first year of being a madricha in 2018, I remember speaking to them about that, and I told them Yom Kippur was my favourite day of the year, and they were beside themselves. They were like, "How could Yom Kippur be your favourite day of the year? We fast and we only daven and all of these really difficult things." And I remember thinking when I was year eight, I would've thought the exact same thing but Bnei Shul really showed me the beauty of it, and really, Yom Kippur is my favourite day of the year because it's - it's so emotional, I can't even explain how it makes me feel.

It's so raw and pure and really so special, it provides me with so much clarity in my life and understanding and direction and I think that maybe the microcosm for Judaism really showed me that there's so much in Judaism that I don't really understand or I don't know or haven't experienced properly and really the beauties that I can gain from it. Certainly, in terms of my davening, Bnei really transformed that and really transformed my experience of davening and connection to Hashem in that way which really is something I'm really, really grateful for.

Interviewer: Thanks, Liba.

Benny: The other thing I think as Rav Taragin said - and he probably says that maybe every time he talks, it was almost a bit of a passing comment - but it had a real impact on me, just that **you can always come back, you can always want to improve**. Work on little things. I think what Jo-Jo said is absolutely important and I remember somebody said that ant Bnei shul actually, I think he's just - every year, take on one little thing, whether it is Modeh Ani or Asher Yatzar, that's my thing for the year. It's like, "Which do I want to focus on? It's that thing and that's how I'm

going to make sure exactly that come om Kippur next year, I know I have grown Jewishly."

Yeah. I think that those are probably two foundational moments for me really. I think also just one more thing, I think the learning is a really important part and I think Jeremy has been really important for me. It wasn't such a given, I was more connected to davening and I didn't think learning was - it didn't turn me on as much but I think - and Jeremy has been really big on this - you need to keep learning.

The point that Jo-Jo mentioned I remember was about constant growth, about always wanting to grow and it's to grow in your learning, to grow in your performance of mitzvot, as a person. **We're all on a downwards escalator. Unless you're actually going upwards, you're actually going to go down and people that stay stagnant or are happy where they are, that's really unattractive to me and I think that people should always want to grow and always want to improve and get better.**

Liba: I remember once when Rav Taragin spoke in Bnei Shul a couple of years ago, I remember him speaking about something and he was saying how he didn't - how much he didn't know about something and I remember him saying, "The more you know, the more you know you don't know," and I remember thinking, 'Wow, such a huge rav,' and had a really big influence probably a lot on my family and my brothers at […] Yeshiva, a lot of people and hearing him say that was really obviously demonstrating that humility but also really opened my eyes to what there is out there in Judaism and to learn and to engage with and to grasp because it's so true.

There is so much that you don't know but you don't know that unless you try and find it. So, I think that as well really makes me think about the way that I interact with learning and those kinds of things as well.

Interviewer: To get that joy of learning, you guys are very, very lucky, lucky to have each other and thank you so much for this little conversation.

END OF TRANSCRIPT

Commented [User18]: 3. Capturing Identity Content in Participant-Generated Terms
This theme focuses on metaphors and labels created by the siblings to define the "substance" of their identity.

Benny uses the "**downwards escalator**" metaphor to describe the need for constant spiritual growth: "Unless you're actually going upwards, you're actually going to go down".